CONSTRUCTIVISM

To discuss constructivism, it will be easier if one follows Figure 1.1 (Chapter 1). Constructivism can be seen to be occupying a 'middle ground' between rationalism comprising the traditional theories of IR and reflectivism consisting of Post-structuralist approaches to IR. The timing of the rise of constructivism is quite striking. The sudden end of the Cold War, the collapse of the Soviet Union and certitude of possible changes that swept over Europe following the end of Cold War marked a need for a new theoretical orientation towards understanding of international events. The factor that spurred the constructivist critique is that the pre-dominant theories in IR failed to predict, and even recognize the possibility that such a dramatic change would happen in international politics. The other thing which became clear is that international relations is not static or fixed, and exists independently of human action and cognition. It can be said that international relations is a consequence of social construction. Constructivism thus became popular with scholars like Alexander Wendt, Nicholas Onuf, Peter Katzenstein and Friedrich Kratochwil giving their valuable insights while contending neo-realists debates forwarded by Kenneth Waltz in his famous work *Theory of International Politics* (1979).

Niclolas Onuf argues that constructivism is not a theory but a way of studying social relations. The core themes of constructivism can be summarized as:

1. International relations is a social construction. Social phenomena such as states or alliances or international institutions or any other phenomena such as states or alliances or international institutions or any other phenomena may build on the basic material of human nature, but they take specific historical, cultural and political forms that are a product of human interaction in a social world.
2. There is a 'social' dimension of international relations. There is an importance of norms, rules and languages in this context apart from exclusive emphasis of realist theory on material interest and power.